

Why we make the choices we do: Social TV viewing experiences and the mediating role of social presence

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ABSTRACT

Although social TV viewing research has been growing, there still exists limited information in this area. To further advance our understanding about this relatively new TV viewing practice, the current study explored motives for social TV viewing (e.g. communication, information, enjoyment), social TV platforms (e.g., public, private), social TV engagement (e.g. active, passive), and social presence. In particular, the study examined social TV viewing for the National Collegiate Athletic Association's (NCAA) March Madness event in the physical co-viewing context by use of an online survey. Primary results found that different motives lead social TV viewers to choose different social TV platforms and to be engaged differently in social TV viewing. Additionally, social presence functioned as a significant mediator between social TV engagement and social TV enjoyment on private platforms. Based on the results, implications for research and practice are discussed to provide a better understanding of how to advance social TV research and keep audiences engaged.

1. Introduction

Sporting events prove to be popular among many individuals. Statistics report that Americans spent nearly 56 billion dollars on attending sporting events during the 2016–2017 sports season (Egan, 2017). However, this is not the only way individuals view sporting events, as individuals often tune in on TV. In 2017, the sports games that received the largest TV viewing audiences included games from the NFL, NBA, MLB, College Basketball (March Madness), and College Football (Sports Media Watch, 2018a). These different sporting events are watched in a variety of places, including at home. The average individual spends almost three hours a day watching TV (Bureau of Labor Statistics., 2018), which includes time spent watching sports. It is estimated that between 30% and 40% of ESPN viewers are tuned in at “out-of-home” locations, such as a bar/restaurant, gym, office, and hotel room (Crupi, 2016).

Of those that are viewing sporting events on TV, many are often engaged with others online. That is, while watching the sporting

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event, individuals are communicating with others online about the sporting event. The concept of communicating with others online while watching TV content is called social TV viewing (Han and Lee, 2014; Kim et al., 2018; Krämer et al., 2015). This is a relatively new way of TV viewing that has recently received a great deal of attention.

Nielsen (2017) found that more than 47% of sports fans go on social media sites while watching sports content, and these individuals engage in various tasks. For example, some viewers are actively engaged in social TV viewing by sharing comments, photos, and videos about the game they are watching and participating in online contests. This type of social TV engagement generally occurs on public platforms, such as Facebook's newsfeed and Twitter's timeline, which broadcast messages to a large audience. In other cases, some viewers may be passively engaged in social TV viewing by reading other active social TV viewers' comments and postings. Further, social TV engagement also occurs on private platforms, such as WhatsApp, text messaging, and messenger on social media, which allow for an intimate and personal interaction with the intended audience (Krämer et al., 2015). In fact, Nielsen (2017) reports that 41% of sports fan contact their friends/family to talk about sports via calling and texting during the game.

Although social TV viewing has been investigated from various perspectives, there still are a few areas that have not been fully addressed in the literature. First, there is lack of information concerning types of social TV engagement. As described earlier, people engage in social TV viewing in various ways (e.g., public vs. private; active vs. passive). However, little has been known about this media engagement in social TV viewing. Second, people may engage in social TV viewing in diverse TV viewing contexts (e.g., co-viewing, solitary viewing), but this aspect has not been fully addressed yet. When people are watching TV with others, they are more likely to socially interact with them, such as conversing about their daily life events as well as the TV content. However, when people watch TV alone, their social interactions would be limited, and they are more likely to focus on the TV viewing. This implies that different contexts of TV viewing may influence social TV viewing patterns, but this aspect has not been considered when examining social TV research. Thus, in order to rule out the potential confounding effect of the TV viewing context, the current study focuses on the social TV viewing phenomenon in a physical co-viewing context only.

Then, why do people still engage in social TV viewing when they are watching TV with others in a physically shared space? The uses and gratification (U&G) framework explains that media users have various motives for a certain media use (Rubin, 1983; Sundar and Limperos, 2013). In this regard, understanding social TV motives in a co-viewing context becomes important. Further, considering that the nature of social TV is based on social interactions online, the role of social presence appears to be important. In particular, research identifies that social presence is one of the most crucial concepts in a mediated environment (Biocca et al., 2003), and it facilitates and promotes positive experiences (e.g., Kim et al., 2018; Kim and Song, 2016; Kim et al., 2019). Taken together, the present study investigates social TV motives, social TV engagement, and social presence. In particular, acknowledging the popularity of sports viewing on TV (Sports Media Watch, 2018a), the current study examines social TV viewing for one of the largest sporting events in the United States, March Madness.

2. Study Context: March Madness

March Madness is a college basketball tournament hosted by the National Collegiate Athletic Association (NCAA) during the month of March. The tournament started in 1939 when the NCAA Division I's men's basketball league was established, and has occurred annually since (Waxman, 2018). It currently features 68 teams through seven single-elimination rounds until one team remains as the winner. The most watched rounds are the National Semi-finals, officially known as the Final Four, and the National Championship (Sports Media Watch, 2018b).

In the 2018 season, March Madness had a total of more than 97 million U.S. viewers throughout the entire tournament (NCAA, 2018). The National Championship alone had a total of 16.5 million viewers tuned in (Otterson, 2018). Additionally, the 2018 March Madness tournament also featured millions of people wagering bets on their proposed brackets. According to the American Gaming Association (2018), it is estimated that more than 24 million Americans bet around a total of 10 billion dollars on the tournament, only 300 million, or 3%, being legal bets. Acknowledging the popularity of March Madness and the notion that sporting events are great avenues for social TV viewing (Harboe et al., 2008), the current study utilizes the 2018 March Madness tournament to study social TV viewing.

3. Social TV viewing

Since the introduction of new media technologies, a relatively new form of TV viewing, social TV viewing, has emerged. Various scholars have generally defined social TV viewing as an act of using social technologies to communicate with others while viewing television content (Harboe, 2009; Kim et al., 2018; Raney and Ji, 2017). Compared to traditional TV viewing, social TV viewing is unique as it requires individuals to be engaged with virtual co-viewers – other social TV viewers connected online. In fact, social TV viewers report that they enjoy sharing the TV viewing experience with virtual co-viewers as opposed to simply watching TV alone (Doughty et al., 2012). In this study, we adopt Kim et al.'s (2018) approach by defining social TV viewing as the act of simultaneously watching TV and communicating with others online that are watching the same TV content.

3.1. Various types of social TV engagement

Social TV viewing occurs through various platforms. Broadly, social TV viewing might exist on two platforms, private and public (Krämer et al., 2015). Private platforms are places where individuals can share content that is targeted to a specific, known audience.

Previous research has identified some private platforms as texting/calling through a mobile device (Vermeulen et al., 2017) and instant messaging applications (e.g., WhatsApp) (Krämer et al., 2015). Public platforms, on the other hand, are places where individuals can share content with a large audience that might not be known. Common public platforms identified in previous research include social media, such as Twitter and Facebook.

Some media platforms include components of both a private and a public platform. This is due to the different features and modes of communication that the platform offers. Facebook, for example, has the option to allow users to either post privately through instant messaging to a small and targeted audience or post publicly to a large audience. In the current study, the focus is on the general nature of the platforms as opposed to the media itself.

There are some notable differences between private and public platforms. First, the audience sizes are different. On private platforms, individuals are often narrowcasting, or communicating with a small group of people (Barasch and Berger, 2014). Conversely, on public platforms, individuals are more likely engaged in broadcasting, or communicating to more than one individual (Barasch and Berger, 2014). Thus, receiving feedback from many others including acquaintances or strangers is possible on public platforms (Panek et al., 2013). Previous research indicates that the audience size dictates how individuals present themselves to others (Barasch and Berger, 2014). Thus, it is likely that individuals might post on a specific platform depending on the outcome they hope to achieve from the audience.

Another major difference is the expectation of privacy on the different types of platforms (Jeong and Coyle, 2014). On private platforms, individuals are likely to engage in private and intimate conversations, which are generally unknown to others (Vermeulen et al., 2017). Conversely, on public platforms, anyone can contribute to or view the conversation, resulting in less privacy. Individuals are also able to view more information about others on public platforms, as basic information is available to the public (Raney and Ji, 2017). Thus, it is likely that individuals choose a specific type of platform based on the type of privacy they hope to achieve.

On the same platform, individuals can engage in social TV viewing in different ways. On private platforms, individuals almost always have an active role in the conversation (Krämer et al., 2015). For example, when an individual is communicating with only one other person, it is difficult for that individual to be passive in the conversation, as that would require a lack of a response. Although some people might not initiate conversations as much as others do, they are still actively engaged by responding to others.

Public platforms, on the other hand, are unique because individuals can either be engaged actively or passively (Lin, 2016). For example, if people are looking for feedback, they might actively engage with virtual co-viewers by messaging and responding to them (Panek et al., 2013). Previous research has found that individuals might be actively engaged because they enjoy it more than simply watching the TV content alone (Doughty et al., 2012). Conversely, Han and Lee (2014) found that individuals are often engaged passively on public platforms when they have a curiosity for others, as people tend to go online to view what others have said about various topics, including TV content. These passive users are lurking, or being present without actively contributing to the conversation, and are hoping to receive some form of information about others. In this essence, some individuals may use public platforms simply to get information (Krämer et al., 2015).

3.2. Social TV motives and social TV engagement

Uses and gratifications (U&G) theory is an active audience-centered approach theory concerned with the motives and gratifications that drive individuals' media choices (Rubin, 1983; Sundar and Limperos, 2013). U&G research, in contrast with previous media effects research, is unique as it suggests that the audience has an active role in media consumption, as compared to previous assumptions that viewed the audience as passive (Rubin et al., 2009). That is, U&G theory views individuals as motivated and goal-oriented *users* in their decision process of why they use and choose different media. Thus, U&G scholars are more concerned with what people are doing with the media they are engaged with rather than the influence that the media has on the individual (Katz et al., 1973; Sundar and Limperos, 2013). From U&G theory, Katz et al. (1973) state that individuals obtain gratifications, or "need satisfactions," from the particular medium they are engaging with when their needs are met by that particular medium. In fact, one of the central claims to U&G theory is that individuals are purposefully choosing specific media that will help them achieve their needs (Papacharissi and Rubin, 2000).

Specifically, scholars have utilized the U&G theory to better understand why users engage with specific media. In particular, motives associated with TV viewing and social media are of importance to this specific study, as social TV viewing requires the user to be engaged with TV and many others via communication technologies such as social media. TV viewing motives, as identified by Rubin (1983), include companionship, entertainment, social interaction, and information-seeking. As technology continued to advance rapidly, Papacharissi and Rubin (2000) revisited U&G theory by providing reasons why individuals use *new* media. The researchers found that individuals use the Internet to socialize with others, seek new information, pass time, be entertained, and use online services. More recently, Quan-Haase and Young (2010) identified four primary motives for social media such as Facebook and Instant Messaging (IM) usage as entertainment, to pass time, to relax, and to escape. Whiting and Williams (2013) found similar results in their study where the five most prevalent motives for social media were social interaction, information seeking, pass time, entertainment, and relaxation. Taken together, these studies provide a foundation for motives and gratifications associated with social TV viewing.

Although limited, some research has examined motives associated with why individuals engage in social TV viewing. For example, individuals often engage in social TV viewing to find out more information about a topic, and to communicate with others by sharing their thoughts about the TV content (Han and Lee, 2014). Similarly, Doughty et al. (2012) found that individuals enjoy talking with others through social TV viewing, which represents the entertainment and communication motives for social TV viewing. More specifically, Krämer et al. (2015) identified three social TV motives: communication, information, and entertainment.

In all, it is evident that much endeavor has been made to understand this unique TV viewing practice, and the literature has been growing rapidly. However, there exists a gap in the extant body of research in associating the motives for social TV viewing on private and public platforms along with the individual's active or passive social TV usage. In order to fill the gap and advance our understanding of social TV viewing practices, the present study examines how individuals' motives are related to different types of social TV engagement. Specifically, based on the social TV motives found in the previous research (Krämer et al., 2015), three of the most prevalent motives are examined: communication, information, and entertainment. Additionally, as mentioned earlier, while individuals could demonstrate different types of engagement (e.g., active, passive), it might be difficult to distinguish them on private platforms due to the nature of the platform and interaction. Thus, overall engagement is being examined on private platforms while active and passive engagement are separately investigated on public platforms. Taken together, the following research questions are proposed.

RQ1a-b: How are social TV motives related to (a) active and (b) passive social TV engagement on public platforms?

RQ2: How are social TV motives related to overall social TV engagement on private platforms?

4. Social TV and social presence

Sociability is one of the defining features of social TV viewing as it provides the opportunity to share TV viewing experiences with others via communication technologies (Lim et al., 2015). Thus, considering the focal aspect of social TV, social presence appears to be an important concept in social TV experiences.

Social presence is generally concerned with individuals' perceptions of social interactions in a mediated environment. When technology users are fully engaged in mediated interactions, they may feel like they are interacting with others in the same space without necessarily noticing the existence of technology (Biocca et al., 2003; Lee, 2004). Simply put, this type of experience is called social presence, a feeling as if someone is around when they are physically away.

Research indicates that when people are involved in media activities, they tend to experience a strong sense of social presence (Witmer and Singer, 1998). In the current study's context, social TV engagement demonstrates individuals' full engagement in media use. For example, whether individuals simply read others' comments or post comments, the additional act itself, while watching TV, is voluntary that media users choose to engage in. Thus, this voluntary act of media use behavior may strengthen social TV viewers' psychological and emotional involvement with the TV content. In all, the existing evidence collectively implies that social TV engagement would be positively related to a feeling of social presence. Taken together, the following hypotheses are proposed.

H1a-b: (a) Active and (b) passive social TV engagement on public platforms positively predict social presence.

H2: Overall social TV engagement on private platforms positively predict social presence.

The next question to follow is what social presence does in the understanding of social TV experiences. A theoretical review of literature has documented that social presence (or presence) has psychological effects on users, such as enjoyment (Lombard and Ditton, 1997). This theoretical argument has been supported in a significant amount of empirical research in diverse contexts (e.g., Kim et al., 2019; Kim et al., 2018; Kim and Timmerman, 2018). Considering that enjoyment is a core media experience (Sherry, 2004), the argument that social presence leads to enjoyment is important to note. In fact, germane to the current study's context, a line of research (Kim et al., 2018; Kim et al., 2019) has documented a positive link between social presence and positive social TV experiences. In this regard, the following hypothesis is proposed.

H3: Social presence positively predict social TV enjoyment.

Based on the arguments presented in H1a-b, H2, and H3, it is important to further investigate the dynamic role of social presence. In particular, the current study is interested in the underlying mechanism of why the act of social TV engagement would lead to social TV enjoyment by focusing on a mediating role of social presence. According to Baron and Kenny (Baron and Kenny, 1986), "mediators speak to *how* or *why* such effects occur (p. 1176)." In fact, a mediating role of social presence has been well supported by extant research (e.g., Kim et al., 2018; Kim and Song, 2016; Kim and Timmerman, 2018; Kim et al., 2019; Lee and Nass, 2005; Song et al., 2019). Germane to the current study's context, Kim et al. (2018) identified a mediating role of social presence in social TV experiences. The study found that social presence is the reason why extroverted social TV viewers enjoy social TV viewing. In similar manner, Lim et al. (2015) also found that social presence mediates the effect of social TV engagement on social TV experiences.

Based on the aforementioned argument, the study predicts that the reason why social TV engagement leads to social TV enjoyment (H1a-b and H2) is because of the feeling of social presence with virtual co-viewers, other social TV viewers that are connected via communication technologies. Specifically, whether social TV engagement is active or passive, this voluntary act of media use behavior, in addition to watching TV, leads social TV viewers to feel strong social presence, and social presence naturally facilitates enjoyment. In this regard, the study proposes the following hypotheses.

H4a-b: Social presence mediates the relationship between (a) active and (b) passive social TV engagement on public platforms and social TV enjoyment.

H5: Social presence mediates the relationship between social TV engagement on private platforms and social TV enjoyment.

5. Methods

5.1. Sampling

The recruitment occurred at a large public university in the U.S. Based on the initial data obtained from undergraduate students enrolled in communication courses, a series of steps were taken in order to finalize the eligible sample for data analyses. First, the recruitment was focused on individuals who had watched at least one of the Final Four games of the 2018 March Madness season, and 251 individuals that met this criterion responded. Then, considering the goal of the study that examines social TV viewing in the physical co-viewing context, the next question asked if they had watched one of the games with other people, and 224 individuals were identified. Next, in order to identify “social TV viewers,” individuals were asked if they had checked social media or other communication media at least once, while watching the game, to communicate about the game. This screening question led to 142 individuals to be potentially included in the sample.

Two more questions were asked to control the quality of the data. First, in the middle of the survey, an attention check was performed by asking the following: “Please click 2 in order to move to the next page.” Of the 142 individuals, 138 individuals passed the attention check. Second, at the end of the survey, individuals were asked if they had taken this survey in other classes. This was necessary to remove multiple responses from the same individual because the survey recruitment was distributed widely across different communication courses. As a result, nine individuals were removed.

In all, the final sample included 129 social TV viewers for one of the Final Four games in the physical co-viewing context. The average age was 20.64 years ($SD = 2.56$). There were more males ($n = 86$: 66.7%) than females ($n = 43$: 33.3%). A majority of the participants were Caucasian ($n = 77$: 59.7%), followed by African American ($n = 18$: 14%), as well as Hispanic ($n = 18$: 14%), and other ethnic groups ($n = 16$: 12.4%).

5.2. Procedure

A survey was distributed via a university-licensed online survey tool. After IRB’s approval, a primary researcher contacted several instructors of communication courses to recruit potential participants. Upon the course instructors’ permission, a recruitment message was distributed. Interested individuals were asked to visit the research participation website to take the survey.

On the first page of the survey, participants were asked to read and acknowledge the informed consent. As described in the sample section, a series of questions were asked to screen out non-eligible participants. Individuals that were identified to be non-eligible were redirected to a set of questions that are not associated with the current investigation.

In order to obtain participants’ experiences as accurately as possible, a recruitment email was sent out one day after the final game of the 2018 March Madness season. Data collection lasted for 10 days. Survey respondents received extra credit for participating in this survey research. Confidentiality was guaranteed.

5.3. Measure

The survey included a set of measures for social TV experiences. First, three motives for social TV viewing were assessed that evaluated why participants engaged in social TV viewing while they were watching the game with others in a physically shared space. Social TV viewing was explained to the participants as described in the earlier section. The *communication motive* ($\alpha = 0.88$) was measured with seven items (e.g., “Because I want to engage in the conversation about the game,” “Because I can express my thoughts about the game situation”). The *information motive* ($\alpha = 0.87$) was assessed with six items (e.g., “Because I can provide useful information to others about the game,” “Because I can ask questions about something I do not know while watching the game”). The *entertainment motive* ($\alpha = 0.76$) was evaluated with four items (e.g., “Because it is fun and enjoyable in itself,” “Because I want to see witty, humorous expressions about the game situations”). Items for the motives were adopted from previous research (Ko et al., 2016). Responses were obtained on a 7-point Likert-type scale (1 = strongly disagree; 7 = strongly agree).

Three types of social TV engagement, which evaluated frequency of various forms of social TV viewing, were examined in the current study. *Active engagement on public platforms* ($\alpha = 0.88$) was measured with eight items (e.g., “Posting game related information on a personal social media page,” “Liking a text post/update about the game related posting”). *Passive engagement on public platforms* ($\alpha = 0.85$) was evaluated with five items (e.g., “Seeing game-related updates on the newsfeed,” “Seeing a game-related video or photo”). Measures for active engagement on public platforms were adopted from Lin (2016). *Social TV engagement on private platform* ($\alpha = 0.80$) collectively assessed social TV engagement without distinguishing active and passive platforms. It was measured with six items, developed for the study, (e.g., “talking about the game via text message,” “... via WhatsApp,” and “...via private messages/chat on social media”). Responses for all three engagement types were obtained on a 5-point Likert-type scale (1 = never; 5 = very frequently).

Social presence ($\alpha = 0.84$) evaluated participants’ feelings about virtual co-viewers. It was measured with five items, adopted from Nowak and Biocca (2003) (e.g., “I felt like as if they were in the same room,” “I felt like they were watching the game together”). *Social TV enjoyment* was measured with six items ($\alpha = 0.93$) adopted from Tamborini et al. (2010) (e.g., “enjoyable,” “fun”). Responses for both social presence and enjoyment were obtained on a 7-point Likert-type scale (1 = strongly disagree; 7 = strongly agree). See Table 1 for descriptive statistics of each variable.

Table 1
Descriptive Statistics.

	α	M	SD
Communication motive	0.88	4.98	1.25
Information motive	0.87	4.68	1.37
Entertainment motive	0.76	5.41	1.17
Active social TV engagement on public platforms	0.88	2.66	0.94
Passive social TV engagement on public platforms	0.85	3.52	0.85
Social TV engagement on private platforms	0.80	2.61	0.88
Social presence	0.84	4.82	1.11
Social TV enjoyment	0.93	5.57	0.97

Note1: Motives, social presence, and enjoyment are on a 7-point scale.

Note2: Social TV engagements are on a 5-point scale.

6. Results

6.1. RQ1a-b and RQ2: social TV motives and social TV engagement

RQ1a-b and RQ2 explored how social TV motives are related to social TV engagement on public platforms (RQ1a-b) and private platforms (RQ2). A set of multiple regression analyses were used to answer the RQs.

Regarding active social TV engagement on public platforms (RQ1a), all motives as a whole explained a significant proportion of variance [$R^2 = 0.28$, $F(3, 125) = 16.20$, $p < .001$]. When examining each motive, all three motives positively and significantly predicted active social TV engagement on public platforms. Specifically, when evaluating the beta weights, the communication motive ($\beta = 0.28$, $p < .01$) was strongest followed by the entertainment motive ($\beta = 0.20$, $p < .05$) and the information motive ($\beta = 0.18$, $p < .05$).

With regard to passive engagement on public platforms (RQ1b), all motives as a whole predicted a significant proportion of variance [$R^2 = 0.26$, $F(3, 125) = 14.63$, $p < .001$]. When examining each motive, the entertainment and information motives positively and significantly predicted passive social TV engagement on public platforms. In particular, the entertainment motive ($\beta = 0.38$, $p < .001$) was stronger than the information motive ($\beta = 0.21$, $p < .05$). However, the communication motive ($\beta = 0.03$, $p > .05$) was not a significant predictor.

About social TV engagement on private platforms (RQ2), all motives as a whole predicted a significant proportion of variance [$R^2 = 0.32$, $F(3, 125) = 19.76$, $p < .001$]. When examining each motive, the communication and information motives positively and significantly predicted social TV engagement on private platforms, with the communication motive ($\beta = 0.36$, $p < .001$) being stronger than the information motive ($\beta = 0.25$, $p < .01$). The entertainment motive was not significant ($\beta = 0.07$, $p > .05$). See Table 2 for RQ1a-b and RQ2.

6.2. H1a-b, H2, H3, H4a-b, and H5: Motives and social presence

H1a-b and H2 explored whether active and passive engagement on public platforms (H1a-b) and engagement on private platforms (H2) are positively related to social presence. A regression analysis was performed to test these hypotheses. The result found that all three types of social TV engagement as a whole predicted a significant proportion of variance [$R^2 = 0.22$, $F(3, 125) = 11.90$, $p < .001$]. However, when examining each type of engagement, which is the unique contribution of each type while controlling for

Table 2
Social TV motives and social TV engagement (RQ1a-b & RQ2).

Social TV motives	Social TV engagement (β)		
	Active engagement on public platforms (Adj $R^2 = 0.26$)	Passive engagement on public platforms (Adj $R^2 = 0.24$)	Overall engagement on private platforms (Adj $R^2 = 0.31$)
Communication	0.28**	0.02	0.36***
Information	0.18*	0.21*	0.25*
Entertainment	0.20*	0.38***	0.07

* $p \leq .05$, ** $p \leq .01$, *** $p \leq .001$.

others, neither active engagement ($\beta = 0.09, p > .05$) nor passive engagement ($\beta = -0.01, p > .05$) on public platforms was significant in predicting social presence. However, social TV engagement on private platforms was a significant predictor of social presence ($\beta = 0.43, p < .01$). Based on the results, H1a-b were not supported, but H2 was supported.

H3 predicted that social presence is positively related to social TV enjoyment. The results indicated that social presence was a positive and significant predictor of social TV enjoyment [$R^2 = 0.24, F(1, 127) = 39.71, \beta = 0.49, p < .001$]. H3 was supported. See Table 3 for H1a-b, H2, and H3.

H4a-b and H5 examined the mediation effect of social presence. Specifically, H4a-b predicted the mediating role of social presence on public platforms between (a) active and (b) passive social TV engagement and enjoyment. H5 predicted the mediating role of social presence on private platforms between social TV engagement and enjoyment. In order to test these hypotheses, a set of PROCESS analyses was utilized. As recommended by Preacher and Hayes (2004), the analysis was conducted with 5000 bootstrapping and the interpretation was performed based on the 95% Confidence Interval (CI). In each analysis, other types of social TV engagement were controlled for. For example, when testing H4a for the active engagement on public platforms, passive engagement on public platforms and engagement on private platforms were controlled for.

Regarding H4a-b on public platforms, results from PROCESS indicated that there were no significant mediation effects of social presence between active social TV engagement and enjoyment ($SE = 0.05; CI = [-0.08, 0.12]$). Additionally, the results did not indicate a mediation effect of social presence between passive social TV engagement and enjoyment ($SE = 0.06; CI = [-0.10, 0.14]$). Thus, H4a-b were not supported.

Regarding H5, the result found that there is a significant mediation effect of social presence on private platforms ($SE = 0.08; CI = [0.07, 0.37]$). In the mediation model, social TV engagement on private platforms was a significant predictor of social presence ($\beta = 0.54, p < .001$), and social presence was a significant predictor of social TV enjoyment ($\beta = 0.38, p < .001$). When considering social presence in the equation, there was no significant relationship between social TV engagement and enjoyment ($\beta = 0.00, p > .05$). In sum, the results indicate that social presence functions as a significant mediator between social TV engagement on private platforms and social TV enjoyment. Thus, H5 was supported. See Fig. 1.

Table 3

Social TV Engagement, social presence, and Social TV enjoyment (H1a-b, H2, & H3).

Social TV engagements	Social presence (Adj $R^2 = 0.20$)	
	<i>t</i>	β
H1a: Active social TV engagement on public platforms	0.84	0.09
H1b: Passive social TV engagement on public platforms	-0.15	0.01
H2: Social TV engagement on private platforms	4.42	0.43***
Social presence	Social TV enjoyment (Adj $R^2 = 0.23$)	
	<i>t</i>	β
H3: Social presence	6.30	0.49***

* $p \leq .05$, ** $p \leq .01$, *** $p \leq .001$.

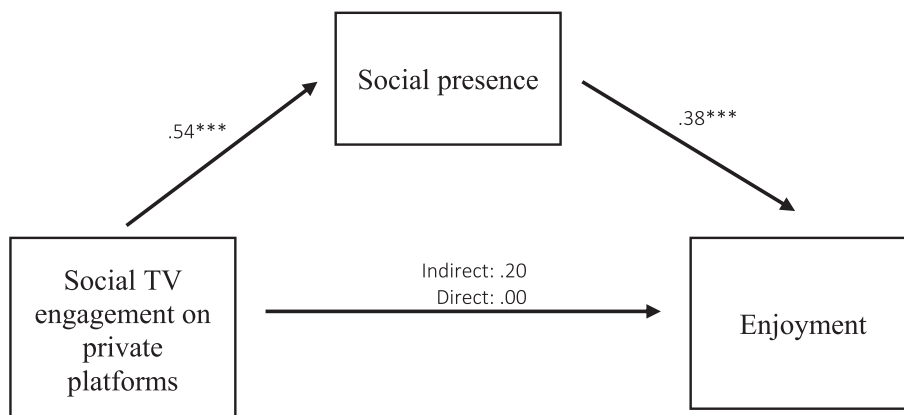


Fig. 1. Mediation effect of social presence on the private platform (H5).

7. Discussion

The current study examined social TV viewing. Specifically, the study examined how motives are associated with different types of social TV platforms and engagement. Further, the study tested the mediating role of social presence in the understanding of social TV enjoyment.

7.1. Findings for social TV motives and social TV platforms

The current investigation found that motives are related to the way individuals engage in social TV viewing. In particular, the communication motive was a significant predictor related to active engagement on public platforms and engagement on private platforms. However, the communication motive was not a significant predictor for passive social TV engagement on public platforms. It is likely that those that are engaging in passive social TV viewing are lurking instead of engaging in the conversations online, as individuals often lurk on social media (Han and Lee, 2014). Thus, they are not playing an active role in the communication process, which might explain why these individuals are not using social TV viewing as a means of communicating with others. On the other hand, those engaging in active social TV viewing on both private and public platforms are actively contributing to the conversation. As stated earlier, due to the reciprocal and interactive nature of communication on private platforms, individuals naturally contribute to the conversations with other virtual co-viewers. This might explain why communication is a motive for active engagement on public and private platforms, and not for passive engagement on public platforms.

Next, the current study revealed that individuals engage in social TV viewing on public platforms for entertainment, but not on private platforms. This finding might be due to the limited nature of private platforms. On private platforms, individuals are engaging in social TV viewing with a targeted and relatively small group of people (Krämer et al., 2015). Thus, it is likely that they are not exposed to new individuals and a wide variety of opinions from others. However, this finding supports previous research for social TV viewing. For example, Doughty et al. (2012) found that individuals engage in social TV viewing because they enjoy it more than watching TV alone. This is likely because those engaging in social TV viewing on public platforms are exposed to many individuals and diverse opinions. Thus, these individuals might be more likely to engage in social TV viewing on public platforms for entertainment.

Further, the information motive was a significant predictor for all of the three different types of social TV engagement. This finding is consistent with extant literature. On private platforms, individuals might text another to find out more information about the content they are watching (Krämer et al., 2015). Similarly, when engaged actively on a public platform, individuals can pose questions to a large audience and receive feedback from many (Panek et al., 2013). Thus, the individual receives information in return for their engagement. Additionally, when engaged passively on public platforms, individuals can lurk and read more information about the content they are watching (Han and Lee, 2014).

The findings also inform which motive predicts each type of social TV engagement the most. For active engagement on public platforms, the communication motive ($\beta = 0.28, p < .01$) was strongest. Considering that the central claim of social TV viewing is about communicating with virtual co-viewers (Kim et al., 2018), it is most likely that individuals are engaging in social TV viewing as a means of communicating. Regarding passive social TV engagement on public platforms, the entertainment motive ($\beta = 0.38, p < .001$) was strongest. This might be due to individuals gaining more enjoyment from their social TV viewing experiences (Doughty et al., 2012). When bored of the TV content that they were watching, individuals might try to supplement their boredom by visiting social media to see what others are commenting and posting. For social TV viewing on private platforms, the communication motive ($\beta = 0.36, p < .001$) was strongest. Considering the interactive and reciprocal nature of private platforms, individuals might expect that they can engage in communication effectively in this manner.

7.2. Findings for social presence in social TV viewing

Another primary finding of this investigation is the mediating role of social presence. Specifically, the study finds that the relationship between social TV engagement on private platforms and enjoyment is fully mediated by social presence. That is, the reason why engagement on private platforms leads to enjoyment is because of social presence. This implies that the simple act of social TV engagement on private platforms would not lead to enjoyment if viewers did not experience social presence of the virtual co-viewers. In fact, the mediation effect of social presence is consistent to the previous findings in diverse social TV contexts (e.g., Kim et al., 2018; Kim et al., 2019; Lim et al., 2015).

Although significant findings tend to always be the highlights of the research, it is also important to address non-significant results. Contrary to the prediction, the study did not find any significant mediation effect of social presence on public platforms. Considering that media users tend to experience some degree of social presence when they are involved in media activities (Witmer and Singer, 1998), this finding is rather surprising. However, when considering the importance of the interactive nature on communication platforms, this result is reasonable to some degree. In other words, merely sharing and posting comments (active engagement) or reading and screening others' comments (passive engagement) on public platforms may not provide a proper level of the interactive nature for the viewers because interaction on public platforms does not always guarantee reciprocity. This can be further explained by the current study's analysis approach. The study controlled for other types of social TV engagement when evaluating each type of engagement in order to assess the distinct features. This approach naturally controls for the nature of private platforms when examining social TV engagement on public platforms. To support this claim, a regression analysis was performed with overall social TV engagement on public platforms, which combines both active and passive engagement, on the feeling of social

presence. The result found that, while controlling for social TV engagement on private platforms, social TV engagement on public platforms did not significantly predict social presence ($\beta = 0.06, p > .05$). Although public platforms provide interactive functionality in the media, it does not guarantee adequate response time or reciprocal interaction due to the nature of the non-targeted audience. Supporting the previous research finding that perceived interactivity and social presence are positively related (Kim et al., 2016), it follows logic that social presence is predicted by social TV engagement on private platforms, but not by engagement on public platforms.

7.3. Implications and contributions

Findings of the current investigation provide significant implications for and contributions to social TV research. First, the study contributes to advancing the further understanding of social TV research. Although there has been an increased attention to social TV viewing, little has been known about differences on types of social TV engagement. In particular, the current investigation contributes to the understanding of which particular motive drives individuals to use a particular medium (e.g., public, private) and how they engage in social TV viewing (e.g., active, passive).

Second, the current research provides a unique contribution to the understanding of social TV viewing in a physical co-viewing context. Social TV viewing could occur in various TV viewing contexts, such as solitary viewing (viewing alone) and co-viewing (viewing with others). Considering that these viewing environments include different levels of social nature in the context, it is important to take this into consideration. By limiting its viewing context to physical co-viewing only, the current study provides the understanding of different motives for social TV viewing when watching TV with others in a physically shared space.

Next, the current investigation builds upon the U&G literature. Previous researchers have identified three motives for social TV viewing: communication, information, and entertainment (Krämer et al., 2015). Based on the extant finding, our findings provide more specific information about the particular motives and gratifications that are associated with active and passive engagement on public social TV viewing platforms and engagement on private social TV viewing platforms. Although general motives and gratifications were previously identified for general social TV viewing, these same motives and gratifications are represented differently when focusing on specific aspects of social TV viewing. These findings collectively re-emphasize the theoretical importance that U&G research should be further investigated by focusing on specific aspects of media as opposed to the overall media, as different motives and gratifications may emerge.

Additionally, the mediation effect of social presence further bolsters the crucial role of social presence in social TV viewing. The extant research has examined social presence as a mediator that facilitates effective virtual experiences in diverse contexts, such as parasocial relationships on social media (Kim and Song, 2016), online education (Song et al., 2019), and exercise video games (Kim and Timmerman, 2018). By examining social presence in the social TV context, the current study bolsters the extant literature. Particularly, the study's finding indicates that social presence is an important aspect to consider when designing social TV programs and platforms, particularly for users who prefer using private platforms.

Further, although social TV engagement on public platforms did not predict social presence in this investigation, there are possible ways that social presence can be better facilitated in the public domain. If individuals are engaged in higher levels of interactivity when engaging in social TV viewing on a public platform, it is likely that they will experience higher levels of social presence. That is, when the individual is directly communicating back and forth with another, they will be more likely to feel as if other virtual co-viewers are around them. Thus, individuals engaging in social TV viewing on public platforms are encouraged to interact with others directly by responding to content in addition to posting their own thoughts and comments on their own social media feed. In doing so, this can help generate a feeling of social presence among the individuals that are engaging in social TV viewing online.

Lastly, the current study provides implications for practice, particularly for TV content creators including programmers, producers, and actors. These creators can utilize the information provided in this study to better understand how to interact with their viewers on public platforms. Whether engaged actively or passively, the study found that individuals are engaging in social TV viewing for information. Thus, creators of content should continue to provide information about their shows, events, and characters as individuals watch TV content. Additionally, the study found that these individuals are also engaged for entertainment purposes. They either enjoy the conversations that they are having with others or they enjoy learning about the conversations that others are having about the TV content. Thus, content creators should continue to cultivate this viewing experience with those that are engaged online. In return, these individuals might be more likely to continue watching and inform others about the content they were engaging with.

7.4. Limitations and future research directions

As with all studies, this study does not go without its limitations. The first limitation is regarding the sample, which consisted of 66.67% males and 33.33% females. Considering that the data were collected in the context of the NCAA's March Madness (College Basketball), it might be logical to have more males than females in the sample. In fact, research has consistently shown that males participate in and spectate sports more frequently than women (Deaner et al., 2016). However, it is not clear if the proportion of each sex in the sample represents that in the population. Also, the popularity of sports among men implies that gender may influence social TV viewing in the context of sport games. However, given the limited scope of this study, the role of gender has not been fully addressed in this research. In this regard, future researchers should consider utilizing either proportional stratified sampling or quota

sampling in order to get a sample that may better represent the population and further examine the role of gender in social TV for sports games.

Second, although the current study selected motives based on previous research (Krämer et al., 2015), the study's findings are limited to these three motives. Since the results show a relatively small percentage of the variance (28% for active and 26.4% for passive engagement on public platforms, 32% for engagement on private platforms), it is likely that there are other motives that explain why individuals engage in social TV viewing. Thus, future research should investigate additional motives for social TV viewing for a more complete understanding of social TV experiences.

Lastly, because the data were collected by limiting the TV viewing context to a physical co-viewing context only, the results might not be applied to other viewing contexts. In other words, it is not clear if a similar or different pattern would be observed among social TV viewers when they watch the TV content alone. Further, the data do not directly answer the question of why TV viewers still engage in conversing with others through social TV viewing even when other people are physically around. In this regard, researchers are encouraged to examine social TV viewing in various TV viewing contexts.

7.5. Conclusion

The current study was conducted in an attempt to respond to the popularity of social TV viewing and to further understand this relatively new form of TV viewing practice. Primarily, the study found that an individual's motives for social TV viewing matter when choosing either a private or public social TV platform and when deciding whether the individual would be actively or passively engaged in social TV viewing. Further, social presence was found to be an important facilitator for social TV enjoyment on private platforms. Based on the current investigation's findings, more research is needed to further understand why people still engage in social TV viewing even when they are watching the TV content with others in a physically shared space.

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